

down or reboot the Raspberry Pi using the 'power off' icon on the bottom-left corner of the XBMC screen. In this way, all software updates, installations and configurations would be saved and will be available on the next start-up.

Step 4: Making smartphone/Android phone as a remote control. Now it is time to control the entire XBMC screen and menu options remotely with your own Android- or iOS-powered phone. It is assumed that you have an android-powered touch phone or an iPhone, and you know how to connect it to your home Wi-Fi network and locate and install apps from respective app stores.

1. Search for XBMC remote app in the respective app marketplace. You will see numerous apps listed. You can install any free app.

2. Open the app, go to settings and enter the connection details (IP address) as shown for your Raspberry Pi + XBMC. You can check your XBMC IP address through 'System→System Info' menu option also.

3. Next, on your XBMC go to 'System→Services' options screen and enable 'Remote control' option and services.

4. Press connect the XBMC remote app on your phone.

Now you can navigate the XBMC and even unplug the USB keyboard and mouse using Raspberry Pi.

Step 5: Setting up some add-ons and accessing YouTube. Next, you may explore some of the cool add-ons and embellish your raspbmc setup with nice functions. You can explore various music add-ons to listen to online radio or MP3 sources over Internet, or picture add-ons such as 'Picasa' or 'Flickr' to view online photo albums. Also, there are various add-ons under video menu, which will bring the huge pool of video content to your TV from sources like live TV sites, or Discovery Channel or NASA videos or Khan Academy or YouTube. Then there are a host of program add-ons which bring in functionalities like accessing your mail, IRC Chat or Facebook content,

or even some games like Sudoku and Tetris.

Note that watching and accessing online content requires decent bandwidth speed (around 2 Mbps or more) and lot of monthly data usage; so make sure you have both in abundance.

Troubleshooting tips

During setup I faced a couple of issues and so thought of listing down some of them under this section as there is no single online article or video which comprehensively captures these issues. The solution to these issues is located across various community forums and discussion boards, and extensive research is needed to get the right answers.

1. Intermittent hang-up of Raspberry Pi. A couple of times during setup, Raspberry Pi becomes unresponsive—requiring it to be turned off and on to resume the setup/configuration. After a bit of R&D, I found that the issue is related to a poor or unstable 5V DC supply. So please make sure that you have plugged in a reliable 5V DC supply in Raspberry Pi with significant amperage. Refer to the link for more details:

<http://forum.stmlabs.com/showthread.php?t=3918>

2. No HDMI output. Whilst powering on Raspberry Pi, if your LCD/LED TV is not on, or is running from a different HDMI input source, Raspberry Pi raspbmc does not send any output on its HDMI port, even when you switch the HDMI in TV to the one plugged in from Raspberry Pi.

This gets resolved by making the below-mentioned entries in the /boot/config.txt file in raspbmc.

```
hdmi_force_hotplug=1
hdmi_drive=2
```

You need to SSH/Telnet into raspbmc using 'pi' user id (default password is raspberry) and do a 'sudo vi /boot/config.txt' to edit it.

3. Issue with Bluetooth/wireless keyboard. Later on I also bought a wireless keyboard with touchpad

(Logitech K400r) to comfortably browse and explore raspbmc. You need to plug the USB dongle (Bluetooth or the one that comes with your wireless keyboard) and the keyboard connects automatically. However, on subsequent restarts, sometimes the wireless keyboard stops connecting. This gets resolved by making the below-mentioned entries in /etc/rc.local:

```
sleep 2
rmmod hid-logitech-dj
sleep 3
modprobe hid-logitech-dj
exit 0
```

Other possibilities to explore

1. Connecting to Facebook and accessing your Facebook feeds from your TV.

2. Setting up your favourite RSS news feeds which would scroll on your XBMC console.

3. Configuring a USB TV tuner card in your Raspberry Pi and leverage the TV headend server, which is now in-built in the XBMC package. This gives you immense control on playing and recording a variety of free-to-air TV channels

4. Configuring your personal pictures and/or videos or movies through a shared storage (home network storage) and access from your XBMC.

5. Play your video from your iPhone/Android phone, laptop or iMac/MacBook and stream it via Airplay on to your LED TV through raspbmc.

6. In case you have home automation setup, there are some nice add-ons to explore which bring entire home automation control panel to your LED TV.

I have not explored all the possibilities here, but there are numerous articles, blogs and self-help videos available online to get you going. ●

Nikhil is an architect working with a leading software development and service provider. He is based at Pune and has keen interest in technology and computers